



Semiotics of the Kitchen

Conceptual Focus

Eating and caring for others are forms of labor.

This series explores how artists—from the seventeenth century to today—turn the acts of cooking, cleaning, and serving into moral, aesthetic, and political subjects.

Students move from seeing domestic work as quiet devotion to understanding it as critique and, finally, as social repair.

Lesson 1 – The Moral Image of Work

Core works:

- Johannes Vermeer, *The Milkmaid* (c. 1658)
- Diego Velázquez, *Kitchen Scene with Christ in the House of Martha and Mary* (c. 1618–20).

Focus: Labor as devotion.

Goals:

Observe how both artists sanctify domestic work through light, gesture, and attention, turning kitchen chores into images of dignity and care.

Key Question:

How does everyday labor become an image of moral or spiritual care?

Lesson 2 - Semiotics of the Kitchen

Core works:

- Mary Cassatt, *The Tea* (1880)
- Martha Rosler, *Semiotics of the Kitchen* (1975).

- Carrie Mae Weems, *The Kitchen Table Series* (1990)

Focus: From domestic ritual to critique.

Goals:

- Read Cassatt's tea ritual for space, gaze, posture, and the roles of host and guest.
- Use Cassatt's compressed, semi-private drawing room as a bridge from devotional attention (Lesson 1) to feminist critique.
- Analyze how Rosler turns tools and gesture into a language of frustration, and how Ringgold uses narrative dinners to reclaim women's creative and social space.
- Discuss how Weems uses the kitchen table as a stage for love, conflict, solitude, and self-definition.

Key Question:

What happens when artists turn maintenance and social ritual into art, and whose labor and agency become visible in the process?

Lesson 3 – Culinary Aesthetics and the Ethics of Care

Core works:

- Rirkrit Tiravanija, *Untitled (Free)* (1992)
- Lee Mingwei, *The Dining Project* (1998)

Focus: Hospitality and participation as ethical art.

Goals:

- Understand cooking, serving, and sharing as artistic media and social sculpture.
- Explore how shared meals can create temporary communities and invite trust, conversation, and mutual care.

Key Question:

Can generosity itself be an artwork, and what kind of ethical responsibilities does it carry?

Link Back to Berger

Each lesson echoes lines from John Berger's *"The Eaters and the Eaten"*:

"The sharing of bread was once a pledge that all would live."

"To eat is to appropriate, to take into ourselves the lives of others."

"To see is already to give something."

Students follow these ideas across the unit:

- From **care and attention**
(*Vermeer, Velázquez, Cassatt*)
- To **critique and awareness of gendered labor**
(*Cassatt in tension, Rosler, Ringgold*)
- To **identity, generosity, and repair**
(*Weems, Bourgeois, Tiravanija, Lee Mingwei*).

Throughout, they ask:

What do we give—and what do we take—when we look, when we eat, and when we share food with others?

 [The Moral Image of Work Introduction](#)

 [Semiotics of the Kitchen Introduction](#)

 [Hyperreality + Paratheatre](#)

 [Culinary Aesthetics and the Ethics of Care Introduction](#)